

Calcium & Protein Cheat Sheet

A one-page food guide for people building bone-friendly meals. Keep it on the fridge.

CALCIUM

1,200 mg

daily, from food first

PROTEIN

at every meal

bone is about half protein

VITAMIN D

2,000 IU

your gut needs it to absorb calcium

POWERHOUSES: MY GO-TO BONE FOODS

Food	Serving	Calcium	Protein	Bonus
Sardines, canned with bones	3.75 oz can	350–380 mg	23 g	150–200 IU vit D + omega-3s
Greek yogurt, plain	1 cup	250–300 mg	15–20 g	often fortified with vit D
Tofu, calcium-set	½ cup	250–750 mg	10 g	label must say calcium sulfate/chloride
Salmon, canned with bones	3 oz	180 mg	17 g	570 IU vitamin D

MORE CALCIUM FOODS

Food	Serving	Calcium
Cow's milk	1 cup	300 mg
Fortified plant milk (soy)	1 cup	300–450 mg
Cheese, hard (cheddar, Parm)	1 oz	200–250 mg
Collard greens, cooked	1 cup	270 mg
Kale, cooked	1 cup	180 mg
Bok choy, cooked	1 cup	160 mg
Chia seeds	2 tbsp	180 mg
Sesame seeds	2 tbsp	130 mg
Almonds	1 oz (23 nuts)	75 mg
Blackstrap molasses	1 tbsp	200 mg
Amaranth, cooked	1 cup	115 mg
Cottage cheese	1 cup	125–150 mg

MORE PROTEIN FOODS

Food	Serving	Protein
Chicken or turkey, cooked	3 oz	25–27 g
Lean beef, cooked	3 oz	25 g
Cottage cheese	1 cup	25 g
Pork tenderloin, cooked	3 oz	22–24 g
Rainbow trout, farmed	3 oz	20 g
Tuna, canned	3 oz	20 g
Edamame	1 cup	17 g
Lentils or beans, cooked	1 cup	15–18 g
Tempeh	½ cup	15 g
Cow's milk	1 cup	8 g
Almond butter	2 tbsp	7 g
Egg	1 large	6 g

WORTH KNOWING

Vitamin D is the gatekeeper. No matter how much calcium you eat, it won't reach your bones without enough vitamin D. I take 2,000 IU daily with a meal that has some fat, and I've got my level checked so I know where I stand. If you have osteoporosis, ask your physician or other healthcare provider to check yours too.

Your body absorbs about 500 mg of calcium at a time. So split your intake across the day instead of loading up at one meal. And don't wash calcium down with coffee: caffeine can bump up how much you lose in your urine.

Not all greens are equal. You absorb calcium from kale (41%) and collards (50%) better than from milk (32%), but only about 5% from spinach because the oxalates lock it up. Bok choy is the mildest of the high-absorption greens and a friendly place to start.

Fortified plant milks vary a lot. Some have more calcium than dairy; some have almost none. Read labels, and shake the carton before you pour, because calcium settles at the bottom.